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Summarize the 1906 San Francisco Earthquake. What factors shaped the current landscape?

The **1906 San Francisco earthquake** was one of the most devastating natural disasters in U.S. history. It struck on **April 18, 1906**, with an estimated magnitude of about **7.9**, rupturing along the **San Andreas Fault** for nearly 300 miles.

What happened

- The quake hit early in the morning, collapsing buildings across **San Francisco** and surrounding areas.
- Broken gas lines sparked **massive fires** that burned for days, destroying more of the city than the shaking itself.
- About **3,000 people died**, and over **200,000 were left homeless** (more than half the city's population at the time).

Key impacts

- **Urban destruction:** Roughly **80% of San Francisco** was destroyed.
- **Infrastructure failure:** Water mains broke, making it nearly impossible to fight fires.
- **Economic shock:** The disaster disrupted national and global markets, given San Francisco's importance as a financial hub.

Factors that shaped today's landscape

1. Earthquake science & fault awareness

- The event led to major advances in understanding plate tectonics and fault behavior, especially the role of the **San Andreas Fault**.
- It helped establish modern seismology in the U.S.

2. Building codes and engineering

- Cities in California now enforce **strict seismic building codes** designed to withstand earthquakes.
- Retrofitting older buildings (like unreinforced masonry) became a priority.

3. Urban planning & rebuilding

- San Francisco rebuilt rapidly but **kept much of its original street grid** rather than adopting radical redesigns.
- However, newer construction used improved materials like steel-reinforced concrete.

4. Emergency response systems

- The disaster exposed weaknesses in coordination, leading to better **fire response, disaster planning, and communication systems**.

5. Population and regional growth

- Displacement pushed development into surrounding areas, accelerating growth in the broader **Bay Area**.

6. Insurance and financial systems

- The earthquake reshaped the **insurance industry**, especially around catastrophe risk and reinsurance practices.

Big picture

The 1906 earthquake didn't just destroy San Francisco—it **reshaped how cities worldwide prepare for disasters**. Today's skyline, infrastructure, and safety standards in California are direct results of lessons learned from that event.

If you want, I can compare it to more recent earthquakes (like 1989's Loma Prieta) to show how those lessons played out.

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